and Julian. The Indian Ocean is the subject of a fascinating work of geography, *The Periplus of the Erythraean Sea*, written by a Greek-speaking Egyptian, which dates from around the first century. Among many other places, the Periplus describes the rich trading port of Broach (in Gujarat), the former royal capital of Ozene (Ujjain) and the rule of the Pandyan in Damirica (Tamil country). [18] There was also an exchange of art between India and Rome: Indian statuary has been recovered from first-century Pompeii in Italy.

The Gupta Period of the fourth to the seventh centuries CE was marked by a flourishing of classical Hindu literature and culture. In inscriptions, Gupta rulers mention the people of Simhala (Sri Lanka) as subordinates, with other sources recalling that Sri Lankan rulers sought the Guptas' permission to build a monastery in Bodh Gaya. Although the literature of the Gupta era is associated with the celebrated playwright Kalidasa and the Panchatantra fables, it also produced political texts such as the *Nitisara* of Kamandaka (also known as Kamandaki). The Guptas, after all, had to contend with feudal politics and foreign invasions, specifically by the Huna who invaded from the north-west. Like its predecessor, Kautilya's *Arthashastra*, the *Nitisara* is a treatise on governance, but differs in a narrower scientific focus on power, on the constraints of governance and ethics, among other areas. [19]

Northern India was, of course, not the only area which interacted with the international arena. In some sense, the ancient coastal states of the Deccan and peninsular India were as much—if not more—involved in trade and cultural exchanges with the world at large. These include the Pallavas in south-eastern India and the Chalukyas in south-western India in the first millennium. The Chalukyas were eventually succeeded by the Rashtrakutas. Throughout this period the export of cloths, precious stones, woods, and oils and the import of such commodities as gold, wines, and horses were productive enterprises, requiring systems of taxation and customs in the ports of the Deccan and Gujarat. Further south, the Cholas, Cheras, and Pandyas—whose histories were captured in classical Tamil literature—jostled for political control and trading routes and privileges.